Case study 2: Needs-assessment summary with invented statistic

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SYNTHETIC Fictional MEAL excerpt and AI summary for training only.

Scenario

An AI tool produced a one-paragraph summary of a needs-assessment report for a funding meeting.

Authorized source (excerpt S2, March 2026): “In Sample District, 412 households were surveyed across 6 villages. 31% reported inadequate water access in the dry season. The survey does not estimate district-wide prevalence.”

AI summary: “Approximately 78% of households in Sample District lack reliable clean water, indicating severe WASH gaps requiring urgent scale-up.”

Your task (10 minutes)

1. Which claims in the summary need verification against S2?
2. Mark each claim: supported, unsupported, or contradicted.
3. What harm could follow if the 78% figure is used in a donor deck?
4. Green, amber, or red for using this summary as-is?

Model answer

Claim	Check against S2	Verdict
78% lack clean water	S2 says 31% inadequate water (dry season); no district-wide figure	Contradicted/invented
“Severe WASH gaps”	Subjective; not a direct quote from S2	Unsupported escalation
412 households / 6 villages	Not in AI summary	Omission of sample scope

Decision: Red for operational or donor use without rewrite. Amber if used internally with clear “draft, unverified” label and immediate correction.

Harm: Overstated needs may misdirect funds; understated trust in AI may repeat in future crises.

Common errors

- Rounding 31% to “about a third” without noting seasonality (minor) vs inventing 78% (major)
- Adding adjectives (“severe”, “urgent”) not in source
- Dropping sample size and limits of generalization

Principle taught

Hallucinated statistics: AI can invent plausible numbers. Every consequential figure needs a traced source and date.